polished stone surface which captures light like an imprisoned spirit and yields colours and shadings that seem to reveal the life of granite. One of the characters, Mrs Moore, dies with the echo of the Marabar Caves in her head; another, Adela Quested, is misled by the echo, 'Ou-boom', in one of the caves into believing she has been molested. Ashoka could not in his wildest dreams have thought that his gift to the Ajivikas would, 2000 years later, result in a classic novel using these caves as the lynchpin of its plot.[7]

Is it possible to demonstrate the planning that went into the Ashokan excavation of these Ajivika abodes? While the caves are of varying dimensions, it has been suggested that they have all been made on a grid using integers of a unit of *circa* 85.5 cm.[8] This would mean that the size of the interiors was not random but based on a fixed measure. Further, the various steps by which this major building work was executed can be partially reconstructed on the basis of clues that the incomplete Lomasha Rishi cave has provided.[9] The fact that this cave's interior was only partially finished reveals that the orders of emperors, even those as powerful as Ashoka, were not always followed in letter and spirit. The messiness of the engravings of some of his edicts at Kalsi and Erragudi suggested this; in the Barabar caves it looks as if the administrators either did not inspect the caves or did not think it necessary to finish them to the required standard. Odd—because Kalsi and Erragudi are at a considerable distance from the Mauryan capital whereas the Khalatika hill is close to Pataliputra, making it easier for the emperor to catch recalcitrant building contractors by the neck. *Plus ça change, plus c'est la même chose*.

For those interested in the technology of their construction, the sloppiness is a blessing. Through the scooping, chiselling, and grinding marks still visible on the floor, ceiling, and walls of the Lomasha Rishi cave, the construction and finishing processes can be reconstructed in some detail. The first stage would have involved removing the rocks to produce a hollow cave. Initially, chunks of rock were removed with the help of short,